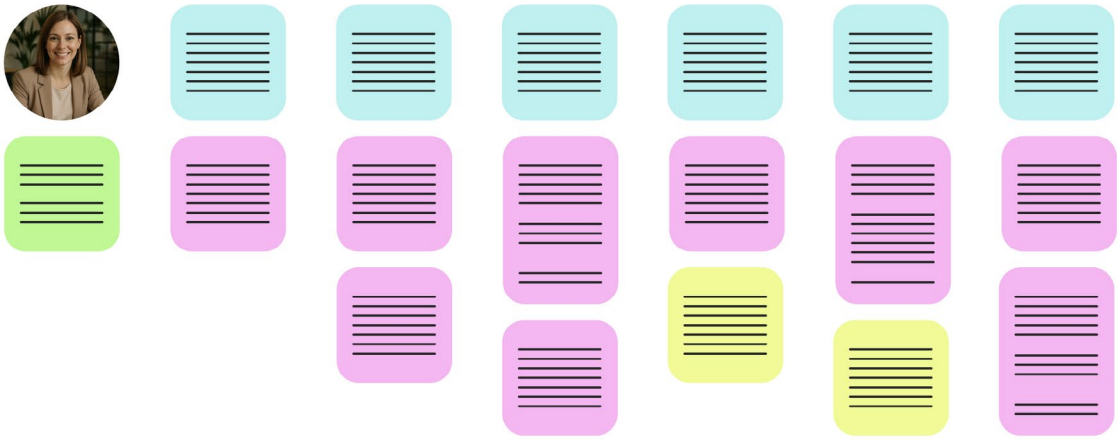

Design Maps

Turn Research and Ideas into Clear, Visual Stories

A design map helps you connect the dots between user goals, ideas, and design decisions. It turns scattered insights into one shared picture, so your team can see the story from the user's point of view and work toward the same vision.

You'll use design maps throughout the object-oriented UI (user interface) design process to bring structure and clarity to your work. They make complexity manageable, align teams faster, and help you communicate your thinking with confidence. It's not about perfect visuals; it's about creating shared understanding and showing the value of your design decisions.

How To Use This Template

Use this template once you've written your stories of use or have a clear idea of how a persona interacts with your product or service.

Follow the step-by-step guide below to get a clear understanding of the process. You'll start small, with one persona and one story, and build out a visual flow that captures each step, question, and design idea along the way.

You can create your map on paper, a whiteboard, or in an online tool like Miro or FigJam. Or, if you want a quick and easy start, use the fillable template below to practice or map a simple user story.

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How to Build a Design Map: Step by Step

1. Start with one persona and one short story

Pick one of your personas and write a short story about how they use your product or service. Or, if you already have a story of use to work with, you can use this.

2. Set up your canvas

You can use paper or a whiteboard with physical sticky notes, or an online tool like Miro or FigJam. Or, if you're just getting started, try **the fillable template below**: it's a simplified design map that's perfect for practicing or working through smaller, straightforward flows.

With your canvas ready, give your map a clear title based on your story so everyone knows what it's about. If you have a photo of your persona, add it here too to help as a visual reference and to boost empathy by giving a face to the name.

3. Map out the user's steps

Across the top, write each step of your story from left to right. Three to seven steps is plenty to keep it simple and focused. Keep the steps short and clear. One short phrase per step is perfect.

4. Add notes, ideas, and questions

Under each step, add sticky notes for thoughts, questions, and design ideas. These can come from anyone on your team, including designers, developers, stakeholders, and others. Where possible, use different shapes or icons (in addition to colors) to keep the map accessible and inclusive.

You can also link to other design maps, ideally using a different-shaped or colored sticky note. This allows you to show how related user stories or flows connect and keep complex experiences easy to navigate.

5. Capture any constraints

Add notes about important constraints, like platform limits, design standards, or technical requirements. These help everyone understand what's possible and what's not.

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6. Add quick visuals

Sketch simple screens or key moments in the story. You don't need to be an artist, and even rough drawings help people picture how the design might work. If you already have visualizations, such as sketches, wireframes, or prototypes, you can include these.

If you don't have time to add visuals right away, no problem. Capture the flow first and add the drawings later when you're ready.

7. Collaborate and refine together

Once your map is laid out, invite your team and stakeholders to take a look. Use their feedback to discuss questions, spot gaps, and refine the design. Don't worry about making it perfect; the goal is to capture insights and decisions as they emerge. Remember, a design map works best when it's shared and evolving. It's a living document, not a final deliverable.

8. Keep it for your handoff or portfolio

When your design map feels complete, save it as part of your project documentation. It's a great way to show how you connect research, ideas, and design decisions.

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Design Map Example

Design Map Title: Megan delivers the presentation

Step 1	Step 2	Step 3	Step 4	Step 5	Step 6	Step 7
Megan logs on to the presentation system.	Megan sees the presenter page.	Megan sees that her slides are ready and she does a last-minute flip through.	Megan sees that audience members are starting to arrive.	Megan communicates with the early arrivals.	Megan decides it's time to start the presentation.	Megan starts her presentation.
Ideas	**Ideas**	**Ideas**	**Ideas**	**Ideas**	**Ideas**	**Ideas**
	The presenter page should reassure her that the streams have started and the preso is good to go.	Let's create a way for her to flip through her slides without any audience members seeing this process.		Let Megan decide if she simply wants to turn on the Q&A tools early...leave it up to her.		
Questions	**Questions**	**Questions**	**Questions**	**Questions**	**Questions**	**Questions**
Should we let Megan log on if Ivan hasn't set everything up yet?	What if an audience member tries to connect before Megan, or even before Ivan?			Can we do this? How do we let Megan communicate with Ivan about any technical issues?	Is there some signal we should send to the audience members, like a countdown?	
Comments or Assumptions	**Comments or Assumptions**	**Comments or Assumptions**	**Comments or Assumptions**	**Comments or Assumptions**	**Comments or Assumptions**	**Comments or Assumptions**
Megan has already uploaded all of her slides.						

Key

- Steps
- Ideas
- Questions
- Comments or assumptions

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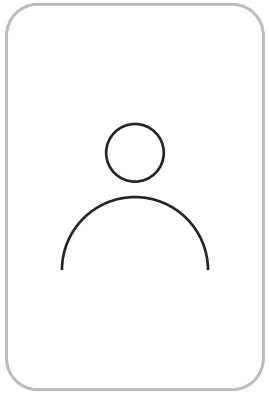
Design Map Template

Design Map Title: _____



Step 1	Step 2	Step 3	Step 4	Step 5	Step 6	Step 7
Ideas	Ideas	Ideas	Ideas	Ideas	Ideas	Ideas
Questions	Questions	Questions	Questions	Questions	Questions	Questions
Comments or Assumptions	Comments or Assumptions	Comments or Assumptions	Comments or Assumptions	Comments or Assumptions	Comments or Assumptions	Comments or Assumptions

Key

- Steps
- Ideas
- Questions
- Comments or assumptions

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Learn More. Change Your Life

Learn how to use this template to its full potential in our online course **Object-Oriented UI Design: Build Interfaces Users Love.** Sign up for it today and learn how to create effective personas from scratch if you're not already enrolled.

Intermediate Course

In this course, you will:

- **Get excited** to transform messy requirements into smooth, user-centered solutions people instantly love. **Most designers have never even heard of object-oriented UI design, the new standard in UX.** This gives you an edge. Research shows that clear, intuitive UI **can double conversion rates**. Object-oriented UI design makes that easy.
- **Make yourself invaluable** by keeping design and development in sync. You'll discover how to avoid miscommunication, impractical proposals, and expensive redesigns, and get **recognition** as the person everyone can **trust to drive real impact with critical projects.**
- **Gain confidence and credibility** as the designer who cuts through complexity and delivers clarity. You'll master how to analyze needs, prevent feature creep, and create interfaces that **stay consistent, intuitive, and scalable.**
- **Craft your personal portfolio** with results that prove your value. You'll create career assets like conceptual models and design maps that show how you can move from requirements to **implementation-ready UIs that users love.**

Learn more about this course >

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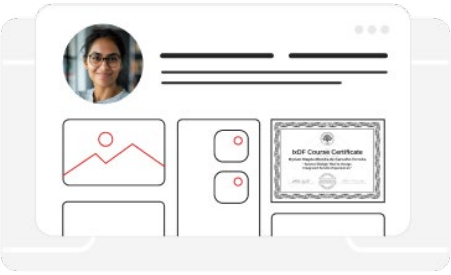

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